

Decide the Smart Way: The Vroom-Yetton Decision Model

The Jerusalem Council (Acts 15)

Opening Case

In Acts 15, the early church faced a crucial doctrinal and cultural conflict:
Should Gentile converts to Christianity be required to follow Jewish law, including circumcision?

Some Jewish believers insisted on it, while Paul and Barnabas strongly opposed it.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Understand the Vroom-Yetton model and its purpose in decision-making.
- Identify different leadership styles (Autocratic, Consultative, Group-based).
- Apply the model to determine the best decision-making approach in various scenarios.
- Evaluate decision complexity and team dynamics in leadership contexts.

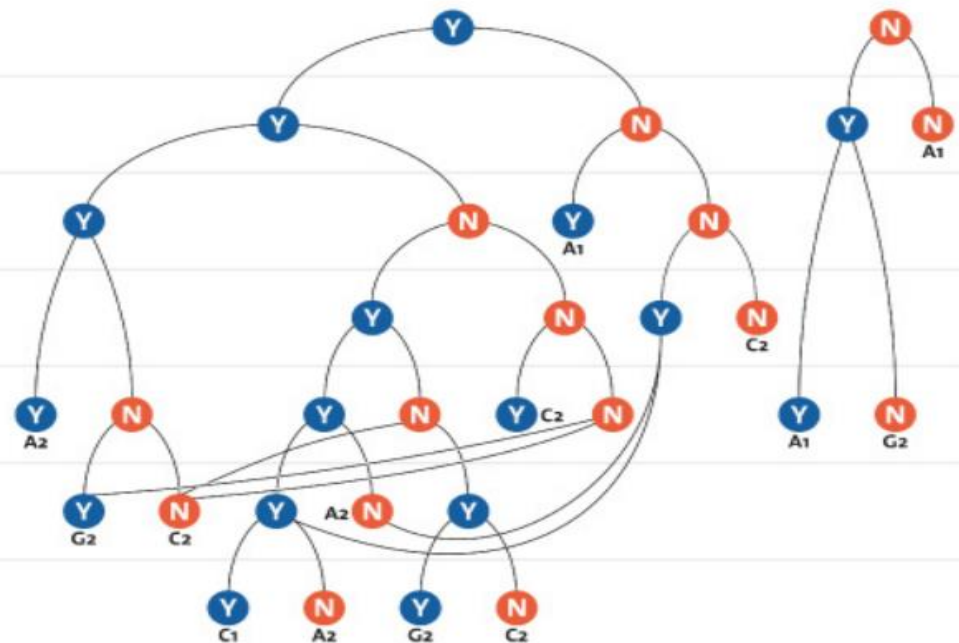
Overview: What Is the Vroom-Yetton Model?

The Vroom-Yetton Decision Model helps leaders decide how much team involvement is appropriate in decision-making. It is especially useful when:

- Decision quality and team commitment are critical.
- Time is limited.
- Conflicts or power dynamics may arise.

The Vroom Yetton Model

1. Is the quality of the decision important?
2. Is the team commitment to the decision important?
3. Do you have enough information to make the decision on your own?
4. Is the problem well structured?
5. If you made the decision yourself? Would the team support it?
6. Does the team share organizational goals?
7. Is conflict amongst the team over the decision likely?



KEY:

Autocratic (A1): You use the information that you already have to make the decision, without requiring any further input from your team.

Autocratic (A2): You consult your team to obtain specific information that you need, and then you make the final decision.

Consultative (C1): You inform your team of the situation and ask for members' opinions individually, but you don't bring the group together for a discussion. You make the final decision.

Consultative (C2): You get your team together for a group discussion about the issue and to seek their suggestions, but you still make the final decision by yourself.

Collaborative (G1): You work with your team to reach a group consensus. Your role is mostly facilitative, and you help team members to reach a decision that they all agree on.

The Vroom-Yetton Decision Tree: Adapted from *Leadership and Decision Making* by Victor H. Vroom and Philip W. Yetton by permission of the University of Pittsburgh Press. Copyright © 1973 University of Pittsburgh Press.



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The Decision Tree Process

The model uses a series of yes/no questions to guide you to one of five leadership styles:

Key Questions:

- Is the quality of the decision important?
- Is team commitment to the decision important?
- Do you have enough information to decide alone?
- Is the problem well structured?
- Will the team support your decision?
- Does the team share organizational goals?
- Is conflict among team members likely?

Decision Styles (Outcomes in the Model)

Leadership Style	Description
Autocratic (A1)	Using an autocratic style of leadership, the leader will make the decision by himself or herself, using the information readily available.
Autocratic (A2)	Using a less stringent autocratic leadership style, the leader will consult the group members to gain more informations, then will make the decision himself or herself. The final decision may or may not be shared with the group.
Consultative (C1)	Using a consultative leadershi style, the leader will consult individuals to seek their opinion. The leader will make the decision himself or herself.
Consultative (C2)	Using a consultative leadership style, the leader will consult the group to seek individual opinions and suggestions. The leader will make the decision himself or herself.
Collaborative (G2)	Using a collaborative leadership style, the group will make the decision. The leader will play a supportive role to ensure that everyone agrees on the decision.

Classroom Activity 1: Case Scenarios

- Breakout rooms. Each group study the Acts 15 Case.
- Apply the Vroom-Yetton Decision Model to the Acts 15 case by answering the following questions and following the decision tree.
- Return to the main room and discuss the result as a class.

Identify Key Leadership Elements	Vroom-Yetton Questions
?	Is decision quality important?
?	Is team commitment important?
?	Do you have sufficient information?
?	Does the team share goals?
?	Is team conflict likely?
Decision Style →	?

Debate Prompt for Class

- Should the apostles have made this decision themselves as divinely appointed leaders—or was it better to include broader voices through a council?
- How does this decision model help prevent division in matters of belief or policy?

Classroom Activity 2: Reorganizing the Sabbath School Ministry Structure

Background

You are the Head Elder of a medium-sized congregation with 200 regular attendees. Recently, the church board has received feedback suggesting that the current Sabbath School class structure is not effectively engaging members—especially youth and young adults.

Some leaders propose reorganizing the Sabbath School format: replacing the current age-group-based classes with more topic-focused, intergenerational discussion groups. This idea would change how teachers are assigned and would affect several long-standing class leaders.

You have the authority to make structural decisions, but how you approach this will impact long-term participation and harmony.

Your Task

As Head Elder, use the Vroom-Yetton Model to determine the most appropriate decision-making style (AI, AII, CI, CII, or GII).

Guiding Questions (from the Vroom-Yetton Model)

1. Is the quality of the decision important? ➤
2. Is team commitment to the decision important? ➤
3. Do you have enough information to make the decision on your own? ➤
4. Is the problem well structured? ➤

5. If you made the decision yourself, would the team support it? ➤
6. Does the team share the organizational goals? ➤
7. Is conflict among members likely over this decision? ➤

Student Instructions

1. Read the scenario carefully.
2. Use the Vroom-Yetton decision tree to walk through the yes/no decision points.
3. Identify the recommended decision style and justify your answer in small groups.
4. Discuss alternative styles that could also be considered based on cultural or spiritual context.

Follow-up Discussion

- How can spiritual discernment be combined with structured decision tools in church settings?

Discussion Questions

- What are the risks of overusing autocratic vs. group-based styles?

Key Takeaways

- Decision style should match the situation.
- Effective leaders are flexible in their approach.
- Team involvement boosts commitment—but isn't always necessary.

When to Use Each Style

Situation	Recommended Style
Problem is well-structured, and leader has full info	AI
Decision needs team support, but leader still controls outcome	CI or CII
Decision quality depends on pooled knowledge	GII
Conflict likely, or team buy-in is crucial	GII
Speed is required, quality is less important	AI or AII